Course Overview

This course equips students to manage products across traditional, digital, and hybrid businesses. It integrates product strategy, customer discovery, agile delivery, pricing, go-to-market, analytics, and growth, while exploring contemporary themes such as AI/GenAI, platforms, India's DPI, and Bharat-focused innovation. Through case-based discussions of Indian and global businesses, students will learn to create customer value, drive sustainable growth, lead cross-functional teams, and navigate the ethical and regulatory challenges of building successful products.

Evaluation Scheme

Component	Weight
Quiz • 3 (10% weight each) • pre-announced, objective, closed-book, paper-based, 30min	30%
Group Project • conducted during Session 19 and Session 20	30%
End Term Exam • Objective (15% weight): closed-book, paper-based, 40min • Subjective (15% weight): open-book, paper-based, 40min	30%
Class Participation	10%

Course Structure

Section I: Foundations and Strategic Choices

Session 1. Product Management Role, Scope and Operating Models

Description

- Define PM accountability for customer value, business outcomes, technical feasibility and operational viability across physical, digital and hybrid products.
- Distinguish product management from project, brand and business management; examine empowered teams and outcome-oriented operating models.
- Explore India's product landscape across FMCG, fintech, digital platforms and technology-enabled services, emphasizing distribution and institutional context.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Digital Disruption at The Vikatan Group: A Case of Adaptation and Strategic Persistence, IMB 905 (2021)

Session 2. Product Vision, Strategy, Portfolio and Lifecycle Choices

Description

- Assess market attractiveness, competitive alternatives and growth potential using market sizing, TAM-SAM-SOM and competitive analysis.
- Translate business strategy into product choices around target markets, differentiated value, capabilities and competitive advantage.

- Evaluate portfolios using BCG and GE-McKinsey matrices alongside strategic fit, investment horizons and product lifecycle decisions.
- Examine cannibalization, brand extensions, build-versus-buy decisions, product renewal and retirement.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: India's Amul: Keeping Up with the Times, HBS 516-116 (2016).

Session 3. Customer Discovery, Jobs-to-be-Done and Problem Selection

Description

- Move beyond demographic segmentation to customer needs, behaviours, contexts, alternatives and desired outcomes using JTBD and problem framing.
- Select qualitative and quantitative research methods based on the decision, distinguishing stated preferences from observed behaviour.
- Explore continuous discovery, evidence quality and GenAI-assisted research, including risks of bias and false confidence.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: IDEO Product Development, HBS 600-143 (2000).

Section II: Product Craft and Execution

Session 4. Value Proposition, MVP and Product-Market Fit

Description

- Translate validated customer problems into differentiated value propositions and coherent product concepts.
- Use MVPs to test critical assumptions through concept testing, prototyping and iterative learning.
- Evaluate product-market fit and pivot decisions, considering affordability, trust, language and distribution.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Dropbox: “It Just Works”, HBS 811-065 (2011).

Session 5. Prioritization, Roadmapping and Agile Product Delivery

Description

- Translate strategy into outcome-based roadmaps, sequencing decisions, dependencies and explicit assumptions.
- Apply RICE, ICE, cost of delay and weighted scoring while recognizing their limitations under uncertainty.
- Examine Agile, Scrum, backlog management, continuous discovery and delivery, technical debt and cross-functional execution.

Pre-reads and cases

- Kniberg and Ivarsson, “Scaling Agile @ Spotify with Tribes, Squads, Chapters & Guilds” (2012).

Session 6. Pricing, Monetization and Go-to-Market Strategy

Description

- Connect pricing to customer value, willingness to pay, competitive positioning and contribution economics.
- Compare subscriptions, usage-based pricing, freemium, bundles and transaction fees across physical, digital and AI products.
- Integrate channel selection, distribution, launch sequencing and sustainable customer acquisition.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Paytm: A Payments Journey in India, HBS 824-039 (2023).

Section III: Measurement, Experimentation and Growth

Session 7. Product Metrics, North Star and Business Outcomes

Description

- Build metric hierarchies linking product strategy to customer value and business performance.
- Apply funnels, cohorts, retention, churn, customer lifetime value, acquisition costs and contribution margin to assess product health.
- Examine instrumentation, vanity metrics, metric gaming and evidence-based continuation or termination decisions.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Reimagining Hindustan Unilever (A), HBS 524-020 (2023).

Session 8. Data-Driven Experimentation and Causal Product Decisions

Description

- Design falsifiable hypotheses and controlled experiments to evaluate product decisions.
- Examine primary and guardrail metrics, statistical power, practical significance, novelty effects and experiment duration.
- Explore experimentation in low-traffic, marketplace and AI products, including ethical limitations and alternatives to randomization.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Booking.com, HBS 619-015 (2018).

Session 9. Product-Led Growth, Activation, Retention and Growth Loops

Description

- Examine how product experience drives acquisition, activation, conversion, expansion and retention.
- Compare funnels with growth loops, referrals, collaboration effects, freemium conversion and product-qualified leads.
- Assess PLG's suitability across consumer, enterprise and low-frequency products, including its interaction with sales- and partner-led growth.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Dropbox: “It Just Works”, HBS 811-065 (2011), revisited for freemium and adoption

Section IV: Platforms and India's Digital Economy

Session 10. Platform Strategy, Network Effects and Marketplace Design

Description

- Distinguish pipeline businesses from multi-sided platforms, examining network effects, cross-side subsidies and cold-start challenges.
- Analyse marketplace liquidity, matching, seller incentives, trust, disintermediation and monetization.
- Evaluate trade-offs between growth and quality, openness and control, and transaction volume and sustainable margins.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Flipkart (A): Transitioning to a Marketplace Model, HBS 516-017 (2015).
- Supplementary case: Flipkart (B): The Ongoing Battle for India's E-Commerce Market, HBS 518-097 (2018).

Session 11. Digital Public Infrastructure: India Stack, UPI and ONDC

Description

- Focus: infrastructure, interoperability and ecosystem governance
- Examine India's DPI across identity, payments and data exchange, distinguishing shared infrastructure from consumer-facing products.
- Analyse UPI's implications for merchant acceptance, monetization, distribution and competition.
- Evaluate ONDC's open-network model, including participant incentives, discoverability, accountability and interoperability.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: India Stack: Digital Public Infrastructure for All, HBS 724-371 (2023).
- Case: Paytm: A Payments Journey in India, HBS 824-039 (2023), revisited for infrastructure, interoperability and ecosystem governance.

Session 12. Designing for Bharat, Super-Apps and Inclusive Product Growth

Description

- Focus: user context, distribution, super-apps and inclusion
- Examine Bharat-focused design across affordability, languages, voice interfaces, connectivity, digital literacy and trust.
- Evaluate distribution through rural retail, merchant networks, social commerce and intermediaries.
- Analyse super-app economics, cross-selling, shared services and the trade-offs between integrated ecosystems and focused standalone products.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: PhonePe: Democratizing Payments in India, HBS 322-053 (2021).
- Case: Meesho (B): Technology Enablement of Small Retailers, IMB 909 (2021).

Section V: AI-enabled and Responsible Products

Session 13. AI/GenAI Product Management: Problem Selection, Design and Evaluation

Description

- Decide when conventional software, predictive AI or GenAI best addresses a customer problem, considering data readiness and build-versus-buy choices.
- Translate probabilistic model behaviour into requirements for quality, latency, hallucinations, human oversight and fallback mechanisms.
- Define evaluation criteria, monitoring and release thresholds for reliable AI products.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Copilot(s): Generative AI at Microsoft and GitHub, HBS 624-010 (2023).

Session 14. Product Quality, Reliability and End-to-End Customer Experience

Description

- Examine reliability, performance, usability, accessibility and service recovery as essential elements of product value.
- Analyse how failures across onboarding, transactions, fulfilment, support and backend systems affect customer trust and retention.
- Explore the trade-offs between feature velocity, technical debt, operational readiness and customer experience.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Flipkart (A): Transitioning to a Marketplace Model, HBS 516-017 (2015), revisited for trust, seller quality and fulfilment.

Session 15. Product Ethics, Privacy, Regulation and Responsible Innovation

Description

- Translate privacy-by-design into requirements for consent, data minimization, retention, security and user control.
- Examine India's DPDP framework and dark-pattern guidelines, alongside their implications for product design and governance.
- Address AI risks, accessibility, sustainability, inclusion and platform fairness as core product requirements.

Pre-reads and cases

- None

Section VI: Leadership and Integration

Session 16. Product Leadership, Stakeholder Alignment and Organizational Execution

Description

- Examine influence without authority, stakeholder management, decision rights and conflict resolution across functions.
- Compare empowered product teams with functional and project-centric organizations, including dependencies and product operations.
- Explore digital transformation, organizational incentives and the leadership needed to change established ways of working.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Transforming Hindustan Unilever, HBS 120-022 (2019).

Session 17. Traditional versus Digital Product Management: Comparative Business Models

Description

- Compare FMCG, SaaS, consumer technology and platform products across development, distribution, pricing and lifecycle management.
- Examine traditional PM's focus on portfolio, brand and physical distribution alongside digital PM's iteration, analytics and network effects.
- Explore how digital capabilities reshape physical products, customer experiences and operating models.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Nestlé's Creating Shared Value Strategy, HBS 716-422 (2015).
- Case: Spotify: Face the Music, HBS I00018 (2024).

Session 18. Product Lifecycle, Strategic Renewal and the Future of PM

Description

- Examine product introduction, growth, maturity, renewal and retirement, recognizing nonlinear lifecycles in software and platforms.
- Integrate strategy, discovery, roadmapping, economics, growth, AI, ecosystems and responsible innovation into product decisions.
- Assess how technology, regulation and competition reshape product strategy while identifying enduring PM capabilities.

Pre-reads and cases

- Case: Reliance Jio: Revolutionizing Indian Telecom, W17175 (2017).

Supplementary Readings

Reading	Suggested use
Apple Inc. in 2019, HBS MH0069	Product strategy and portfolio choices
Netflix, Inc.: The Disruptor Faces Disruption, HBS W17722	Pricing, GTM and competitive disruption
Airbnb, Inc., HBS MH0072	Metrics, analytics and growth
Meesho (A): Exploring Hyperlocal Fashion, IIM Bangalore, IMB907	MVP, market development and Indian e-commerce
Unified Payments Interface (UPI): Crafting the Ecosystem, IIM Bangalore, IM145B	Digital public infrastructure and ecosystem governance
Open Network for Digital Commerce: Democratizing Marketplaces, Ivey W36944	Open-network marketplace dynamics
What's New? Tata Neu's Differentiation Dilemma, Ivey W38316	Super-app strategy and ecosystem integration
Unilever in India: Hindustan Lever's Project Shakti: Marketing FMCG to the Rural Consumer, HBS 505-056	Bharat-focused distribution and inclusive growth